How to Research Your Candidates

Where the public records on your candidates are, how to open them, and what to look for. From the talk at Roy Southwest Library, Saturday, Oct. 17, 2026.

Posted Oct. 17, 2026 · Updated Oct. 17, 2026

Why research your candidates

Every candidate on your ballot has already filed public records about themselves: who pays for their campaign, what businesses they own, and what boards they sit on. Almost nobody reads them. This guide shows you where those records are, how to open them, and what to look for. It takes about 30 minutes per candidate, and none of it costs money or needs a login.

Why it matters:

- **Many races are decided early.** On Weber County's 2026 ballot, Commission Seat B, Assessor, Attorney, Clerk/Auditor and Sheriff each have one candidate. Those choices were made at the convention and primary, months before November.
- **The forms are self-reported.** Candidates fill out their own disclosure forms. The state and county post them as filed. Anyone can compare them with other public records, and this guide shows you how.
- **Ads tell you what a candidate wants you to know.** The records tell you who is paying, what they own, and what they have done.

The Hive does not tell anyone how to vote. This guide is about how to look, so you can decide for yourself, in any race, in any year.

Ground rules before you start

These are the rules the Hive uses. They keep your findings fair and keep you on solid ground if you share them.

1. **Records, not rumors.** Use forms, reports, registry filings, minutes and the candidate's own public words. A Facebook post or a tip tells you where to look, not what is true.

2. **Write down where you found it.** Save the link, the name of the report and the date you looked. Records change and pages move.
3. **Not found is not the same as not there.** If you can't find something, say where you looked. Don't treat a missing record as proof.
4. **Look at the actual page.** Many county forms are scanned images. A computer reading one can make a filled-in form look blank. Open it and read it with your own eyes before saying anything is missing.
5. **Use plain, neutral words.** Say what the record shows: "reported," "listed," "did not list." Leave legal conclusions to judges.
6. **Same test for everyone.** Check every candidate in a race the same way, whatever their party.
7. **The record, not the reputation.** A candidate's good or bad name elsewhere doesn't answer the question in front of you.

Step 1: See your own ballot

Start with the races you will actually vote in. Weber County is split between several House districts and two congressional districts, so your neighbor's ballot may not match yours.

Where: vote.utah.gov

How:

1. Click **Learn about candidates & issues**.
2. Type your home address.
3. Write down every race and every name. That is your research list.

Also on vote.utah.gov: Track my mail or provisional ballot, **Learn About Judges on the Ballot**, and the Voter Information Pamphlet for Amendments A and B.

How I use it: I make a list of every race on the ballot first, then decide which ones to look at. Races with only one candidate still get a look, because that person will hold the office.

Step 2: Find out where the candidate files

The office decides where the records are. Look up the race in this table before you search.

Office on your ballot	Money reports	Conflict-of-interest form
Utah House, Utah Senate, State School Board	disclosures.utah.gov	disclosures.utah.gov
Weber County Commission, Attorney, Clerk/Auditor, Sheriff, Assessor	weberelections.gov/financialdisclosures	Same page lists sitting officeholders' forms. For a newer candidate, ask Weber County Elections.
Ogden and Weber school boards	weberelections.gov/financialdisclosures	Ask Weber County Elections
U.S. House	fec.gov	disclosures-clerk.house.gov
City council and mayor (odd-numbered years)	Your city recorder	Your city recorder

Good to know:

- The Weber County page is under **Candidates**, then **Financial Disclosures**. Reports are listed by name and office, with a link for each report (Convention, Primary, Pre-General, Final).
- Older county reports are at the bottom of the same page (2012 through 2024).
- disclosures.utah.gov also keeps a folder of county and city filings by year: disclosures.utah.gov/municipal, then **Weber**.
- Weber County Elections: 2380 Washington Blvd., Suite 320, Ogden · 801-399-8034 · elections@weberelections.gov

State law (Utah Code §17-70-304) says a county candidate's conflict-of-interest form must be filed with the declaration of candidacy and posted on the county website. If you can't find one, the elections office is the place to ask.

Step 3: Read the conflict-of-interest form

This is the candidate's own list of what they own, where they work and what boards they sit on. It is the single most useful record, and the shortest to read.

Where: for legislative and State School Board candidates, disclosures.utah.gov → **Search by Name** → type the candidate's last name → open their folder → look for the conflict-of-interest disclosure. For

county offices, see Step 2.

What the state form asks for:

- Employer and job
- Businesses the candidate owns or runs
- Income sources of $5,000 or more
- Stocks and bonds worth $5,000 or more
- Board seats, paid or unpaid
- Spouse's employer, and other adults in the home

What to write down: every business, board and employer on the form. You will check each one in Step 4.

What to keep in mind:

- The law lets candidates withhold some details, and some sections are optional. A blank line is not automatically a rule broken.
- The form asks about the year before. A job that ended recently may be listed or not.
- The form never asks about relatives outside the home. Family ties won't show up here.
- Note the date on the form. Legislators file new ones each year, so compare the newest with older ones.

How I use it: I read the form first, before the money, because it tells me which names to watch for in the donor list. One Weber County example: Rep. Katy Hall's January 2026 form listed her company, Tava Town LLC. Her July 2026 form answered "n/a" on owned businesses. Putting the two forms side by side is how that showed up.

Step 4: Check the form against the business registry

The state business registry lists every company, LLC and nonprofit registered in Utah, with the people who run it. If the registry shows a candidate in a role the form leaves off, that is worth noting.

Where: businessregistration.utah.gov (Utah Division of Corporations). Searching is free.

Two ways to search:

- **Search by a person's name (Registered Principal Search).** Type the candidate's name. This shows companies where they are listed as an officer, manager, member, director or registered agent.

- **Search by business name (Business Registration Search).** Type a company name from the form or the donor list. Open the result, then click **Access Principal Information** to see who runs it.

What each record shows: the entity number, type, status (active, expired, delinquent), the date it was formed, the registered agent, the principals and the addresses.

Then check the candidate's own words. Campaign websites, bios and social media often list boards and businesses. So do board rosters posted by cities, nonprofits and homeowners associations.

What to keep in mind:

- Common names bring up strangers. Match the middle initial and address before counting a result.
- Check each company's status and dates. A company that expired years ago tells a different story than an active one.
- Unpaid boards matter too. The Hive treats a homeowners association or nonprofit board seat as a board seat.

How I use it: I search every candidate's name, then every company name on their form and on their donor list. Two Weber County examples from the Hive's case files: the registry lists Speaker Mike Schultz as director of one homeowners association and officer of another, while his 2026 form answers "None" to the board question. For Senate District 5 candidate Jill Koford, the registry shows three roles not on her form: director of North Fork Meadows Owners Association, manager of Scoots Industries LLC, and director of Ogden Regional Airport Association.

Big tip: OpenCorporates for companies outside Utah

Utah's registry only shows Utah companies. Many campaign vendors, donors and developers are registered in other states, like Delaware, Nevada or Wyoming.

Where: opencorporates.com. It gathers company records from more than 140 government registries in one search.

How:

- Type a company name in the search box. Choose **Companies** to find the business, or **Officers** to search a person's name across every registry at once.
- Open a result to see where it is registered, its status, its officers and its filing dates.

- Click through to the original state registry. OpenCorporates copies government records, so the state's own page is the record to cite.

How I use it: when a company on a donor list or a disclosure form doesn't show up in Utah's registry, I check OpenCorporates next. Searching a person's name under **Officers** has turned up companies tied to the same home address that I wouldn't have found one state at a time.

Step 5: Follow the money

Campaign reports list who gave money, how much, when, and what the campaign spent it on. The question is simple: who is paying for this campaign?

For legislative and State School Board candidates: disclosures.utah.gov

To see one candidate's reports:

1. Go to disclosures.utah.gov and click **Search by Name**.
2. Type the candidate's last name and open their folder.
3. Open each report. The 2026 reports run Convention, Primary, September 30th, General and Year End. The 2026 deadlines are posted on the home page.

To see money from every filer at once (the bigger picture):

1. Click **Advanced Search**.
2. Pick an **Entity Type** and a **Report Year**, then click **Find**.
3. In the top row of results, click the year under the far-right column, **Download Data by Year**.

This download is how you find money a candidate received from a PAC even before the candidate's own report is posted, because it shows what the PAC reported paying out. It also shows everything one donor gave to everyone that year.

For Weber County candidates: weberelections.gov

Go to weberelections.gov/financialdisclosures. Find the candidate's name and click each report link. These are PDFs, and most are scanned. Read them page by page.

What to look at

- **People or organizations?** Add up how much came from individual people and how much from PACs, businesses and party committees.
- **Who lives in the district?** Donor addresses show whether the money is local.
- **Timing.** Money that arrives right after a primary, or the day before a vote, is worth noticing.
- **Late entries.** Utah law says each contribution must be reported within 31 days of receiving it. Compare the date received with the date it first appeared. In the 30 days before the general election, candidates in a contested race must report each contribution within seven business days, per the state's disclosures home page.
- **Deleted and amended entries.** Changes to a filed report are allowed. A lot of them, or one big gift that disappears, is worth a second look.
- **The candidate's own money.** Loans and gifts from the candidate or their household are part of the picture.
- **Where the money goes.** Look at the biggest payees. Then look them up in the business registry (Step 4).

How I use it: I sort the donors into groups: individuals, caucus and leadership PACs, other organizations, party help, and the candidate's own money. One Weber County example: in HD-7, a $500 gift to Rep. Ryan Wilcox dated July 8, 2026 first appears in his filings on Sept. 30, 84 days later. That comes straight from comparing the two dates on his own report.

Step 6: Look behind the PACs, and check lobbyists

A PAC's name tells you very little. A name with "taxpayers," "families" or "values" in it says nothing about who is behind it. Every PAC files its own reports on the same state site, so you can see who runs it and who funds it.

How:

1. On disclosures.utah.gov, click **Search by Name** and type the PAC's name.
2. Open its folder. The registration lists its officers, such as the chair and treasurer.
3. Open its reports and look at who gave the PAC money, and who else the PAC gave to.

Lobbyists: lobbyist.utah.gov shows who is registered to lobby and for whom. Use **Lobbyists by Organization (client)** to see who a company or city hires, or **Public Search** to look up a person.

What to look for:

- The same officers or treasurer showing up across several PACs.
- A PAC that pays its own officers' companies.
- The same few PACs funding many candidates in your area.
- A donor, vendor or lobbyist who is related to or does business with the candidate.

How I use it: I look up the PACs on each candidate's donor list. In Weber County, three PACs show up again and again in the Hive's case files: the House Speaker Leadership PAC, the Utah House Republican Election Committee (UHREC) and NUPAC. They list the same treasurer, Kyle Palmer, whose firm Irish Elk LLC is paid by those PACs and by candidates. Giving to candidates and paying a treasurer's firm are legal. The voter's question is who funds those PACs, and what a network funding many candidates at once expects from them.

Big tip: the Meta Ad Library, for Facebook and Instagram ads

Campaign reports show a payment to an ad firm. The Meta Ad Library shows the ads themselves: what they said, who paid for them, roughly how much was spent, and who saw them. Ads about politics, elections and social issues stay in the library for seven years, even after they stop running.

Where: facebook.com/ads/library. Anyone can search it.

How:

1. Set the location to **United States**.
2. Set the ad category to **Issues, elections or politics**.
3. Type a candidate's name, a PAC's name or a keyword in the search box.
4. Results show active ads first. To see older ads, change **Active status** to active and inactive under **Filters**.
5. Click **See ad details** on an ad.

What each political ad shows:

- **Paid for by:** the disclaimer naming who paid. Meta requires it on political ads.
- **Amount spent and impressions,** given as ranges, not exact figures.
- **Who saw it,** by age, gender and state.
- The dates it ran, and the platforms (Facebook, Instagram).

Spending by state: the Ad Library Report shows the biggest advertisers by location. Click **Utah** under spending by location to see the top 10 here. Not every advertiser on that list is political, so check each name. The full list can be downloaded near the bottom of the page.

What to look for:

- Ads from a PAC or group whose name you don't recognize. Look up the "Paid for by" name on disclosures.utah.gov (Step 6).
- Ads about a candidate run by someone other than their campaign.
- Compare the spending range with what the campaign or PAC reported for advertising on its state report.

What to keep in mind:

- A keyword search also finds ads that just mention a name. Check the "Paid for by" line before counting an ad.
- Spending is a range, so don't quote it as an exact amount. Say "Meta's Ad Library lists between $X and $Y."
- This only covers Facebook and Instagram. Google keeps its own political ads library, and TV, radio and mail ads aren't in either one.

Step 7: Check the record

Campaign promises are easy. A record shows what someone did when it counted. If a candidate has held any office or sat on any public board, there is a paper trail.

Bills and votes (sitting legislators): le.utah.gov

- Type your home address in the box on the home page to see who represents you.
- Open a legislator's page to see the bills they were primary sponsor of.
- Open a bill to see each version, the committee votes and the floor votes. Compare the first version with the one that passed. Bills can change a lot along the way.

Meetings of cities, counties, school boards and special districts: utah.gov/pmn (Utah Public Notice Website)

- Under **Browse for Notices**, pick a **Government Type**, then the **Entity**, then the **Public Body**.

- Agendas and many minutes are posted there. Minutes show who voted how, and whether anyone disclosed a conflict before a vote.

The candidate's own words: campaign website, newspaper interviews, candidate forums and BallotReady profiles.

What to compare:

- What the candidate says they did, next to the bill, vote or minutes.
- What they promise on taxes, water or growth, next to how they voted on it.
- Whether they stepped aside on votes that touched their own business or board.

How I use it: I treat a candidate's description of their own record as a claim until I can match it to a bill, vote or set of minutes. On the Hive's pages, a candidate's description is labeled "in their own words" and sits next to what the record shows.

Big tip: the Wayback Machine

Websites change. Bios get rewritten, board lists get updated, and pages come down. The Wayback Machine keeps saved copies of web pages from the past, so you can see what a page said before it changed.

Where: web.archive.org (the Internet Archive)

To see an old version of a page:

1. Paste the page's address into the search box. Keep it simple, like electionhive.com or a candidate's "about" page.
2. A calendar opens. The bar across the top shows how often the page was saved each year. Click a year.
3. Days with a saved copy are marked on the calendar. Click a day, then a time.
4. The page opens as it looked on that date. Write down the date at the top. That is your citation.

To save a page yourself: use **Save Page Now** on the same site. Paste the address and save it. If the page changes or comes down later, your saved copy stays, with the date it was taken.

What to keep in mind:

- Not every page was saved. If there's no copy, that doesn't mean the page never existed.
- A saved copy shows what the page said on that date, not why it changed.

- Compare old and new versions side by side, the same way you compare an old and new disclosure form.

How I use it: I check old versions of candidates' campaign sites, company "team" pages and board rosters. One example from my files: Election Hive's website once ran a bio page for Dan Hemmert, now MIDA's executive director. The page has since been taken down, but the Wayback Machine's saved copy still shows it. Before you share something you found on a website, save the page yourself, in case it changes.

Federal sites: Congress, judges and federal money

U.S. House (Weber County is in District 2 or District 3): fec.gov

- Type the candidate's name in the search box at the top. Their page shows total raised, total spent, cash on hand, and how much came from individuals versus PACs.
- Click into the reports to see each donor and each payee.
- Super PAC spending for or against a candidate is listed separately as independent expenditures.
- A candidate only has to register with the FEC after raising or spending $5,000, so small campaigns may not appear.
- Members of Congress also file yearly financial disclosures at disclosures-clerk.house.gov.

Judges on the retention ballot: on vote.utah.gov, click **Learn About Judges on the Ballot**. The Judicial Performance Evaluation Commission (judges.utah.gov) posts an evaluation for each judge, with its recommendation and the survey results behind it.

More federal sites worth knowing:

Site	What it shows	How to search
fec.gov	Money raised and spent in races for Congress and president, including super PACs	Type a candidate, PAC or donor name in the search box
disclosures-clerk.house.gov	U.S. House members' and candidates' yearly financial disclosures and stock trade reports	Search by the member's name

Site	What it shows	How to search
efdsearch.senate.gov	U.S. Senators' and Senate candidates' financial disclosures, 2012 to now	Check the box agreeing to the use rules, then search by name
usaspending.gov	Federal contracts, grants and loans, and who received them	Start Searching Awards → add the company under **Recipient** → Submit Search
IRS Tax Exempt Organization Search	Whether a nonprofit is tax-exempt, and copies of its Form 990 returns	Search by organization name or EIN

How to use them together: if a company gives to a candidate, check usaspending.gov to see whether it also receives federal money. If a nonprofit shows up on a form or a donor list, the IRS search shows whether it is really a tax-exempt nonprofit, and its 990 lists its officers and pay.

How the Hive grades what it finds

You don't need a grading system to research a candidate. But if you want to compare candidates fairly, it helps to use one scale for everyone. This is the one the Hive uses.

The five questions:

Question	What it asks
Power	Does this add or remove a check the public would otherwise have?
Transparency	Can the public actually see it: disclosed conflicts, itemized money, posted hearings?
Financial accountability	Who pays, who is protected from paying, and is it shown plainly?
Environmental impact	What happens to water, wetlands and wildlife, and is it treated as a real limit?
Community impact	Who bears the cost, and did they get a real say?

The scale:

Grade	What it means
A	Goes well beyond what the law requires, in ways the record shows
B	Goes beyond the requirement
C	Meets what the law requires, and no more
D	The required information is there, but vague, lumped together, or late
F	Required information is missing, or a public check is removed with nothing in its place

Campaign money, Power: the share of counted money that comes from individual people. A = 90% or more, B = 67–89%, C = 34–66%, D = 10–33%, F = under 10%. Party help and the candidate's own money are shown but not counted.

Disclosure forms: one item voters can't see anywhere else (a company, a board seat, a job) left off = D. Two = D−. Three or more = F. No form on file = F. Anything named anywhere on the form counts as listed.

A grade can change. An amended form or report that adds what was missing changes the grade.

Filing deadlines: know when the next report is due

Deadlines tell you two things: when new information will show up, and whether a report came in on time. A report filed on its due date is on time.

State candidates (Utah House, Senate, State School Board) and PACs, 2026, from the Lieutenant Governor's 2026 Financial Disclosure Deadlines:

Report	Covers	Due
Convention	Jan. 1 to 5 days before it's due	7 days before the convention
May 15th	Jan. 1 – May 10	May 15
Primary	Convention – June 11	June 16
September 30th	June 12 – Sept. 25	Sept. 30

Report	Covers	Due
General	Sept. 26 – Oct. 22	**Oct. 27**
Year End	Oct. 23 – Dec. 31	Jan. 10, 2027

Reports are due by 11:59 p.m. on the deadline. Between reports, each contribution still has to be entered within 31 days. In the 30 days before the general election, a candidate with an opponent has seven business days.

Weber County candidates: reports are filed with Weber County Elections and posted on weberelections.gov/financialdisclosures by name: Convention, Pre-Primary, Primary, Pre-General and Final. The county says failing to file can disqualify a candidate, and a report must be current within three days of filing. Call 801-399-8034 for this year's exact dates.

U.S. House candidates (FEC), 2026:

Report	Covers through	Due
October Quarterly	Sept. 30	Oct. 15
Pre-General	Oct. 14	Oct. 22
Post-General	Nov. 23	Dec. 3

Conflict-of-interest forms: due before or at filing for office (Jan. 2–8, 2026 in Weber County). Sitting legislators and State School Board members file each year, and again when their job changes.

Tip: put the deadlines on your calendar and check the reports the day after each one is due. Then compare each contribution's date received with the report it first appears on.

Common traps

- **"Campaign Expense" isn't the whole story.** The state's public report shows the category of each payment. A description the candidate typed in may not show on the public report, so don't say a candidate gave no description. Say "the public report lists it as 'Campaign Expense.'"
- **A scanned form can look blank.** Many county filings are images. Read them page by page with your eyes.

- **The address column is the donor's address,** not the candidate's.
- **Same name, different person.** A name search catches strangers with the same name. Check the address and middle initial.
- **The same company under different names.** One vendor can appear as "Roost," "Roost Co." and "Roost & Company." Search for the short name.
- **In-kind gifts don't change the cash balance.** Donated services or goods are listed, but they aren't counted in the running total.
- **Small unknown gifts are allowed.** Contributions of $50 or less from an unknown source are permitted by Utah law (Utah Code 20A-11-301), so they aren't a missing item.
- **Dates drift.** The same check can be dated a day apart on the giver's and receiver's reports. That is normal filing lag, not a discrepancy.
- **Pages go out of date.** Board lists, websites and business filings change. Note the date you looked.

Quick reference: every site in this guide

All of these are free. Sites change their buttons now and then. If a label in this guide has moved, look for similar words.

Site	What you'll find there
vote.utah.gov	Your ballot, ballot tracking, judges, the voter pamphlet
weberelections.gov	Weber County dates, vote centers, drop boxes
weberelections.gov/financialdisclosures	Weber County candidates' money reports and officeholders' conflict forms
disclosures.utah.gov	Legislative and State School Board money reports, conflict forms, PACs
disclosures.utah.gov/municipal	County and city filings by county and year
businessregistration.utah.gov	Who owns and runs a Utah company, LLC or nonprofit
lobbyist.utah.gov	Registered lobbyists and their clients
le.utah.gov	Your legislators, bills, versions and votes

Site	What you'll find there
utah.gov/pmn	Meeting notices, agendas and minutes for local bodies
fec.gov	Money in congressional races
disclosures-clerk.house.gov	Members of Congress' yearly financial disclosures
judges.utah.gov	Evaluations of judges on the retention ballot
The Hive's 2026 case files	Every race the Hive has reviewed, with sources
The Hive's Weber County voter guide	What the records show for Weber County races
Questions every candidate should answer	The Hive's questionnaire to bring to a forum
web.archive.org	Old versions of web pages, and Save Page Now
opencorporates.com	Companies and officers across 140+ registries, including other states
efdsearch.senate.gov	U.S. Senators' and Senate candidates' financial disclosures
usaspending.gov	Federal contracts, grants and loans, by who received them
IRS Tax Exempt Organization Search	Nonprofit status and Form 990 returns
2026 state filing deadlines	When each state campaign report is due
facebook.com/ads/library	Political ads on Facebook and Instagram: who paid, spending range, who saw them, plus spending by state

Weber County dates, and where to send what you find

Date	What happens
Oct. 13	Ballots mailed. Drop boxes are at every city office in Weber County, every county library, the Weber Center parking lot and Weber State.

Date	What happens
Oct. 23, 5 p.m.	Regular voter registration deadline. Same-day registration is available on Election Day.
Oct. 27–30	Early in-person voting, noon to 6 p.m., Weber Center basement, 2380 Washington Blvd., Ogden
Nov. 3	Election Day, 7 a.m. to 8 p.m. Vote centers: Weber County Fairgrounds Exhibit Hall (1000 N 1200 W, Ogden) and Ogden Valley Branch Library (131 S 7400 E, Huntsville). Mailed ballots must be received by 8 p.m.

If you are mailing your ballot close to the deadline, a drop box is the safer choice. Questions: Weber County Elections, 801-399-8034.

Found something? Send the link and the name of the record to the Hive at webercountyhive@gmail.com. Every tip is checked against the records before anything is published.